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REST API TUTORIAL INSIGHTS

My greatest takeaway from this tutorial is that REST is an architectural style and not a protocol. An API being called “RESTful” is often just an HTTP API. To make an API “RESTful” it needs to have hypermedia as the engine of application state and meet 6 certain constraints. I also was reminded how HTTP methods map to operations on resources and why method properties are important in this structure. GET is safe because it never changes server data. PUT and DELETE are idempotent and not safe because they do change data, but they are idempotent. If we send the same request multiple times this leaves the server in the same state as sending it once, so a second request of this kind would change nothing. For example, a PUT that sets a user’s name to “Cassidy,” will have the same result every time it is run. DELETE twice would also end up with the same result twice. A second call would return a 404 instead of 204, but it is still idempotent since idempotency relies on server state not response. This is important to know so that we can design APIs that help clients safely retry idempotent requests after failure without breaking our website with duplicate data or unintended changes. I also learned that good resource naming uses plural nouns and hierarchy, such as /customers/12345/orders, and lets the HTTP method act as the verb!